

Chapter 72-1

It was currently rush hour. On the asphalt road, traffic flowed like water, and the chaotic red tail lights reminded people that night was falling.

Along the roadside were office workers coming and going, gathering in groups of three to five, chatting and laughing as they walked toward the nearby subway station.

Xu Qingzhu's long hair was blown by the wind. She wore five-centimeter heels, revealing her fair ankles. Black pencil pants wrapped around her calves, slender and straight. Her body proportions were enviably superior.

Liang Shi stood beside her in a light gray trench coat, paired with a white shirt and black pants—all minimalist attire.

Liang Shi was 1.72 meters tall, six centimeters taller than Xu Qingzhu in bare feet. However, she would change back into flat shoes when driving after work, so standing beside Xu Qingzhu now, visually the two appeared about the same height.

Both equally tall and slender, both with excellent body proportions.

Liang Shi walked slightly ahead of Xu Qingzhu, attempting to shield her from something.

Su Meiqi suddenly grabbed Zhou Yi'an's sleeve tightly. "Sister An, these two look so good together!"

Zhou Yi'an: "....."

Quite an eyesore.

Su Meiqi's eyes sparkled brightly. She rushed over first and called out to Xu Qingzhu, "Sister Xu."

Then she greeted Liang Shi, "Sister Liang."

Last time after coming down from Yunfeng Mountain¹, Su Meiqi had naturally become familiar with the two of them in the car.

Now meeting them again, she was still as naturally friendly.

"What a coincidence." Su Meiqi said, "What are you two going to do? On a date?"

"Mm." Liang Shi answered first: "Planning to go eat."

"Us too." Su Meiqi said, "To celebrate me finding a job, my aunt is treating us to dinner."

"That is quite a coincidence." Xu Qingzhu's expression was cold, but her gaze fell on Su Yao.

Su Yao wore sunglasses, stood elegantly with a slender neck, and her naturally black hair made her skin appear fair.

There was no indication at all that this was a woman in her early forties.

Xu Qingzhu suddenly thought of a phrase: Time never defeats a beauty.

Because Sheng Yu tilted her head first and said, "It's Rainbow's mommy's colleague."

Su Yao then looked toward Liang Shi. She smiled and nodded, "What a coincidence, we meet again."

"Mm." Liang Shi maintained a polite yet distant demeanor throughout, "Hello."

Little bean² Sheng Yu, as if afraid of being ignored, tried her best to assert her presence. Looking up, she asked Liang Shi, "Auntie, do you work here?"

Liang Shi: "....."

Suddenly felt like her knee had taken an arrow³.

But she couldn't say anything, so she could only answer: "My wife is here."

"Wow." Sheng Yu's eyes turned into hearts, "This sister is so beautiful."

Liang Shi: "?"

Are you being polite?

Liang Shi's expression changed slightly, but she didn't quibble with a five-year-old child over the form of address. Instead, she said ambiguously, "You'll be this beautiful when you grow up too."

Following Sheng Yu's words, Su Yao finally turned her gaze to Xu Qingzhu.

More accurately, they locked eyes.

A few seconds later, tears slid down Su Yao's face.

Xu Qingzhu frowned slightly. She pressed her lips together and looked at Su Yao, asking with a somewhat sharp momentum, "Do you know me?"

Su Yao was dazed. She shook her head extremely slowly, like a body that had been stiff for a long time just starting to move.

"Then you....." Xu Qingzhu had just started her sentence, her belly full of aggressive questions not yet spoken, when she saw Su Yao open and close her mouth, trying to speak several times but unable to, while two clear tears slid down her face.

Su Meiqi panicked and immediately searched for tissues in her bag, asking in a low voice, "Auntie, what's wrong?"

Only then did Su Yao realize she had shed tears. She immediately raised her hand to wipe them, and in her panic knocked off her sunglasses, revealing one lifeless eye, while the other eye was red-rimmed and brimming with tears.

Xu Qingzhu pressed her lips together. Her hand resting on Liang Shi's gripped tighter, as if drawing strength from her.

After Su Yao wiped away her tears and put her sunglasses back on, she apologized in a gentle voice, "Miss, I'm sorry, I... lost my composure."

"It's fine." Xu Qingzhu paused, "May I ask, if you don't know me, why did you show me such an expression? This creates misunderstanding."

Su Yao shook her head, "I don't know."

Her voice was muffled, hoarse from sobbing, "I have no idea what happened."

In fact, when she saw this young lady before her, her mind went completely blank.

It was as if some natural emotion was driving her tear glands, making her cry inexplicably. Even after she came to her senses, she didn't know what she was doing.

This question—she wanted to ask it herself.

But Su Yao could only shake her head, "I truly apologize."

Her tone was sincere and carried guilt, making it hard for anyone to give her a hard time.

But Xu Qingzhu had already walked over and taken the first step, so naturally there was no reason to retreat.

She showed a reasonably appropriate smile, "Is it because you've seen me before?"

"No." After facing her, Su Yao seemed somewhat wooden, only shaking her head lightly: "I don't think I've ever seen you."

"But you give me a very familiar feeling." Su Yao looked at her features and pressed her lips together, "You look somewhat like my husband."

"Your husband?" Xu Qingzhu's tone rose, "Is he this little friend's father?"

"Yes." Su Yao said, "He passed away."

Footnotes:

¹ Yunfeng Mountain: A location referenced in previous chapters where these characters had an encounter.

² Little bean (小豆丁): A Chinese term of endearment for small children, literally "little bean," used to describe someone who is small and cute.

³ Took an arrow to the knee: An expression meaning to feel hurt or attacked. Liang Shi feels this way because Sheng Yu called her "auntie" instead of "sister" (which would imply she looks younger), then immediately called Xu Qingzhu the more youthful-sounding "sister."